Don't Get Scammed

A friendly 45-minute talk on phone, text and online scams

BEFORE WE START

Nobody here is being tested

- Scammers are professionals; this is their full-time job
- Doctors, bankers and police officers get fooled too
- If it's happened to you, you're in good company, and it's not your fault
- Today: what to look for, what to say, and who to call

WHY THIS MATTERS

Scams are big business

- Americans report billions of dollars lost to fraud every year (FTC)
- Older adults report losing more money per scam than younger people
- Most scams start with a phone call, a text or a pop-up
- Most can be stopped by one habit: hang up and call back

REMEMBER THIS IF NOTHING ELSE

Every scam has the same 3 warning signs

1. Hurry: “You must act right now.”
2. Secret: “Don't tell your family or the bank.”
3. Strange payment: gift cards, wire transfer, crypto, cash by courier, or a code.

Phone calls

Family emergencies · government imposters · your “bank”

PHONE CALLS

“Grandma, it's me. I'm in trouble.”

- A crying “grandchild” or a “lawyer” says they need bail or a hospital payment today
- They beg you not to tell Mom or Dad
- AI can now copy a voice from a short video clip
- Fix: hang up and call your grandchild or their parent on the number you have
- Agree on a family safe word

PHONE CALLS

Social Security, the IRS and Medicare don't call to threaten you

- “Your Social Security number has been suspended” – it can't be
- “There's a warrant for your arrest” – agencies don't call to arrest people
- “Your Medicare card is expiring, read me your number” – new cards are free
- Fix: hang up and call the agency on its official number

PHONE CALLS

“This is your bank's fraud department”

- Caller ID shows your bank's real name: that can be faked
- They ask you to read back a code “to stop the charge”
- Or to move your money to a “safe account”
- Your bank will never ask for a code or ask you to move money to protect it
- Fix: hang up and call the number on the back of your card

PRACTICE

What would you do?

Your phone rings at 7 a.m. A young man crying says, “Grandpa, I was in a car accident and they've arrested me. Please don't tell Mom. My lawyer will call you about bail.”

What do you do? Talk it through in pairs for 60 seconds.

Texts, email and computers

Fake delivery texts · scary pop-ups

Don't tap the link

- “Your package can't be delivered, pay $1.99”
- “You owe an unpaid toll, pay now to avoid a fine”
- “Your account is locked, tap here”
- Fix: go to the company's app or website yourself
- Forward scam texts free to 7726, then delete them

COMPUTERS

The scary pop-up

- A loud warning: “Virus detected! Call Microsoft now”
- Real warnings never give you a phone number to call
- Never let a stranger control your computer
- Fix: close the browser, or turn the computer off and on
- Already let them in? Turn it off and call your bank

PRACTICE

What would you do?

You're reading the news online. Your screen goes red, an alarm sounds, and a message says: “Your computer is locked. Call Windows Support at 1-8XX-XXX-XXXX immediately.”

What do you do? Talk it through in pairs for 60 seconds.

Online friends

Romance · “sure thing” investments

When a new friend needs money

- Someone you met online who soon says they love you
- Who can never meet or video chat
- Who then needs money, or shows you how much they've made on an investment app
- Never send money, gift cards or crypto to someone you've only met online

PRACTICE

What would you do?

You've been messaging a kind widower for two months. He's working on an oil rig overseas. Today he asks you to buy $500 in gift cards to pay a customs fee so he can finally come home to meet you.

What do you do? Talk it through in pairs for 60 seconds.

PRACTICE OUT LOUD

Your hang-up lines

1. “I don't do business on the phone. I'll call you back on the number I have.”
2. “I'm going to check with my family first.”
3. “No, thank you.” (And hang up. You don't owe them a goodbye.)

IF IT HAPPENS

The first hour

Stop. Don't send any more money.

- Call your bank on the number on your card
- Gift cards? Call the card company on the number on the back
- Tell someone you trust. It's not your fault
- Report it: ReportFraud.ftc.gov, or the Elder Fraud Hotline 1-833-372-8311
- Beware “recovery” callers who promise to get your money back for a fee

QUESTIONS

Questions, and take a handout

- The large-print handout has the warning signs, hang-up lines and official numbers
- Write your bank's number and a trusted contact on it tonight
- Free weekly scam alerts: [newsletter link]
- Scam Decoded for Seniors, the full large-print pack: [link]